EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Do We Crave Power and Revenge?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:10-13

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Chapters 10 to 13: building up the world, long life, status and power, and revenge

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 8 December 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Six Extremes So Far

This was the last shiur of the term. The Rabbi said he would decide over the winter holidays which sefer the class would learn after finishing Emunot VeDeot.

The tenth essay is about the best way to live. Saadia opened by explaining that the most important thing in life is **balance**, never being extreme in any field, and listed thirteen areas where people often go to extremes. Six have been covered:

#	Extreme	Saadia's correct use
1	**Abstinence**	Only to keep away from what is forbidden: food, drink or relationships
2	**Food and drink**	For sustaining life. "Of course you can enjoy what you eat and drink, but primary purpose is to sustain a person"
3	**Intimacy**	Primarily to continue the human race, though it has other purposes
4	**Passion**	Within a marriage
5	**Wealth**	The desire exists so that we look after our property, like Yaakov Avinu in last week's parasha, Vayishlach
6	**Children**	Not just quantity but quality: within a framework of how we will provide for them and educate them

Tonight: building up the world, long life, and status, and, if time allowed, revenge. It did.

Chapter 10: Building Up the World (*Yishuv HaOlam*)

Their argument

ראו אנשים אחרים כי הישוב טוב מכל מה שיתעסק בו האדם

The seventh group says the best thing a person can do is develop and build up his environment:

- **Houses** are essential: without them a person has no shelter from heat and cold, and nowhere to gather his friends.
- **Fields** are needed for food, without which no one can survive.
- Both bring a person joy, breadth of heart and serenity. **ויתרון ארץ בכל הוא, מלך לשדה נעבד**: a man with a worked field feels like a king.
- Kings and princes take pride in their buildings, **מלכים ויועצי ארץ הבונים חרבות למו**.
- The Torah promises it as a reward: **ובתים מלאים כל טוב אשר לא מלאת**.

The Rabbi added a modern version: "Life is about making this world a better place. You often hear this." That's lovely, "but then the next generation, what's their purpose?" If that is all, the question just passes on.

Saadia: wrong, when it excludes everything else

והתבוננתי בדעת אלה ומצאתים טועים, כאשר חייבו עזיבת כל דבר והעסק בשער הזה

1. **Building needs other wisdom.** No one can build properly without knowledge of the land, its regions, and mathematics to work out measurements. Without broad knowledge "the thing sought will not be reached." It cannot stand alone.
2. **Worry, toil and other people's money.** One who throws himself into building ends up in great anxiety and strain, spending money, even other people's money, in his craving to finish what he started. The Rabbi: "I would say councils may fall under this. They have a desire to improve their council, they end up having to tax their residents more." **הוי בנה ביתו בלא צדק ועליותיו בלא משפט, ברעהו יעבד חנם**. You may want lots of property, but not at the expense of integrity.
3. **Disappointment.** Even if he completes his project, he may see something wrong in it and feel all his toil was in vain. **ויצא חירם מצר לראות את הערים אשר נתן לו שלמה ולא ישרו בעיניו**. Constant anguish and pressure.
4. **Jealousy.** It arouses the envy of others and the anger of kings: **בתי גזית בניתם ולא תשבו בם**.
5. **Fields are not in your control.** They grow by the will of the Creator. You need rain and Hashem's blessing. There may be drought, blight, mildew and locusts: **רעב כי יהיה בארץ, דבר כי יהיה שדפון ירקון ארבה**.
6. **Taxes.** The demands of kings and their officials can leave him almost nothing. The Rabbi: "In some countries you're paying loads of tax to the extent where it's actually not worth making any more money." **ברבות הטובה רבו אוכליה**.
7. **Exploiting the poor.** Even if he gathers his crop, he will want to hold it back for times of scarcity and sell at extravagant prices, taking what little the poor have, **לקנות בכסף דלים ואביון בעבור נעלים, ומפל בר נשביר**.

Why the desire exists

ולא נתנה אהבת הישוב בלב האדם כי אם לתקן בו צרכו בלבד

The love of building was placed in us only so that we provide for our needs: **ויושב שם רעבים ויכוננו עיר מושב, ויזרעו שדות ויטעו כרמים**. A place to live and food to eat, "and that's about it."

The Rabbi linked it to the Mishnah in Avot, **מרבה נכסים מרבה דאגה**: more property, more worry. "Yes, we do have a desire to have nice homes and to have nice fields and that's good… but that's it. It shouldn't go beyond that." He did not want to dwell on it: "it's pretty straightforward."

Chapter 11: Long Life

"This is interesting because you hear this a lot nowadays: people who think life is all about living the longest life."

Their argument

ראו אחרים כי הטוב שידרוש האדם בעולם הזה השגת אריכות חייו

- With long life a person can achieve whatever he wants, in Torah and in worldly matters. Without it, what can he keep?
- The Torah constantly promises it: **למען יאריכון ימיך**, **למען תחיה וימים רבים**.
- Its causes, they say: good food and drink in moderation, not overexerting oneself, keeping oneself happy, and avoiding danger, spiritual or physical. The Rabbi noted that the link between happiness and longevity "is really proven nowadays as well."

So they exercise, look after their bodies and spend their lives pursuing a long life. "Obviously it's a bit circular, that."

Saadia's first argument: it does not work

ואמנם כי הדברים האלה מתקנים הגוף, אבל אינם סיבה לחיים

These things make for a healthy body but are not the cause of a long life. We find people who live this way and die young, and others who do the opposite and live long. Some bodies are strongly built and fail quickly; others are frail and endure. And if comfort and good food lengthened life, **היו המלכים מאריכים ימים יותר מכל אדם**, kings would outlive everyone.

Here the Rabbi disagreed. "I'm not sure if this would be true nowadays." There are exceptions, but statistically, the more a person looks after his health, the longer he lives. He asked the class which country has the highest life expectancy. Someone suggested Japan: "Japan's very close." The answer, from what he had read about two years earlier: **Monaco, 89 years**. England was around 81 or 82. "On average, people from wealthy countries who have had better food and better lifestyles, they live longer." So "that's not his strongest argument."

Saadia's second argument: what would you want it for?

Saadia returns to the pessimistic view of this world he has expressed before in the book. The Rabbi stressed, as each time, "this is his outlook, not necessarily agreed upon by all."

כי אדם כל אשר יארכו ימיו ירבו יגונו ודאגותיו וצרותיו

The longer one lives, the more one's sorrows, worries and troubles: **צרות לבבי הרחיבו**. And the more sins one accumulates, renewed every day.

Then he goes through the stages of life:

Stage	Saadia's description	Verse
Childhood	Foolish, knows nothing	**אולת קשורה בלב נער**
Youth	Moves into recklessness and waste	**נער משלח מביש אמו**
Adulthood	Enters toil and labour	**נפש עמל עמלה לו**
Old age	Everything he desired is forbidden to him and he must still struggle	**ימי הרעה... אשר תאמר אין לי בהם חפץ**

In old age a person loses his radiance, moisture, sensitivity and strength, and becomes like a cloud whose rain has gone, dry and of no use: **עד אשר לא תחשך השמש והאור והירח והכוכבים ושבו העבים אחר הגשם**. "A nice analogy," said the Rabbi. "You've got a cloud, but there's nothing there."

So which part of life is the best? When young you lack understanding; by the time you have it you must work hard; by the time you stop working, life is no longer worth living. "So what do you want long life for?"

The Rabbi pushed back: "If you take the argument to its logical conclusion, then we should commit suicide, right?... I find that very difficult."

Why we love life

והאדם הצדיק אוהב חיים בעולם הזה כי אם בעבור שמדרגה יגיע בה ויעלה ממנה לעולם הבא, לא בעבור עצמו

The righteous love life in this world only as a stage from which to rise to the World to Come, not for its own sake. That, the Rabbi said, "is agreed upon by all."

ולמה נתנה אהבתה בלב האדם, כי אם שלא ימית את עצמו כשתבוא עליו צרה

Why did Hashem place the love of life in us? So that a person would not kill himself when trouble comes, as it says, **ואך את דמכם לנפשתיכם אדרש**. Sadly, the Rabbi noted, even that powerful drive is sometimes not enough.

The Rabbi: long days, not long years

"Not necessarily, I don't think necessarily one has to agree with such a view." David HaMelech says, **ימי שנותינו בהם שבעים שנה ואם בגבורת שמונים שנה ורהבם עמל ואון**, which we say at a funeral. That does not mean life is not worth living. Life is worth living while recognising its difficulties and challenges.

His own point, which he said was not Saadia's: the Torah never says "long life." It says **אריכות ימים**, **למען יאריכון ימיך**, long *days*. "That's why we wish in English, when someone dies, long life. It's not precise. We don't have an expression in Hebrew for long life." **ואברהם זקן בא בימים**, as the class read a couple of weeks earlier: he came with his days.

It is not the accumulation of years but the accumulation of days, which means maximising a person's potential. Someone can live many years with empty days, never having unlocked their ability. Others live short lives in years but very long lives in what they achieved:

- **The Arizal** died at 38.
- **The Ramchal, Rabbeinu Moshe Chaim Luzzatto**, died at 38.
- **Rebbe Nachman of Breslov** lived only 38 years.

"They had short days, but they had a long life in the sense that their days were filled."

The conclusion is close to Saadia's ending: there is no intrinsic value in pursuing life for its own sake. Life is for making the most of it, preparing ourselves and maximising our potential "so that we're able to create the best ourselves and the best identity for the world to come." And the circularity is an obvious fallacy: if the purpose of life is a long life, what is the purpose of the long life?

Chapter 12: Status, Power and Dominion (*Serarah*)

Their argument

ראו אחרים כי הגדול שבמה שיתעסק בו האדם בעולם הזה הגאוה והגדולה והשררה

The ninth group says the greatest thing to pursue, more than money, children or life itself, is being raised above others and holding power over them.

- **The soul naturally inclines to greatness,** and finds lowliness hard, **ותראה שקשה לה השפלות לאדם אחד ולהודות לו**: it is hard to submit to another person or concede to him.

The Rabbi drew out the psychology. "Why is it so hard for us to apologize to someone or to admit we're wrong? Because that means I'm lower than you." If I admit a mistake, you did better than me, so you are higher than me. "I can't accept that you're higher than me, so therefore we find ways of not apologizing. That's the simple psychology."

- **Power strengthens a person,** giving him a sense of height, energy and expansiveness.
- **Giving orders is pleasant.** "You can tell people, do this and don't do that. That's a lovely thing to be able to do."
- **Without authority the world would not be ordered.** Kings lead in war and defence; judges judge; officers correct those who do not know. The Rabbi: in every industry "you need the CEO, the people at the top to lead things."
- **The Torah gives it as a blessing to the righteous:** in Toldot, a couple of weeks earlier, Yitzchak blessed Yaakov, **יעבדוך עמים וישתחו לך לאמים, הוה גביר לאחיך**.

Saadia: necessary, but they forgot wisdom

מה שזכרוהו מסדור העולם בשמירה ובמשפט, הענין הנני מודה בו

The need for authority to keep society in order: Saadia agrees completely. But they have taken it too far. **סידור העולם לא יקום כי אם בחכמה**: the world is ordered only by wisdom, and they dropped wisdom and made power itself the goal. The Rabbi: "Who do we put in positions of authority? We put wise people." You cannot pursue power for its own sake. You pursue other things, develop yourself fully, and then you may be someone able to lead.

The damage of arrogance

Saadia then lists what they forgot:

- **He leaves his path.** When a person grows proud and great in his own eyes, he becomes arrogant towards his relatives and friends, and sees himself as if he were **יחיד בעולם**, unique in the world.
- **He despises all advice.** Whatever anyone says, he rejects. **לתאוה יבקש נפרד, בכל תושיה יתגלע**: the one who sets himself apart rejects all counsel. "Because I'm separate, I'm distinct, I'm unique."
- **He dismisses the experience of elders,** what they learned over long lives. **דרך אויל ישר בעיניו**.
- **His affairs go wrong,** because he takes no advice, and when they go well he credits his own strength: **כי אמר בכח ידי עשיתי**, of the king of Assyria.
- **He argues with craftsmen about their craft** and with scholars about their science, and tries to refute them. People think him a fool, though they won't say it to his face. **ראית איש חכם בעיניו, תקוה לכסיל ממנו**. The Rabbi: at least the simpleton knows he needs advice. "A person who's arrogant and thinks they know everything, they've got no hope." **חכם עצל בעיניו משבעה משיבי טעם**.
- **He speaks against kings and rulers,** and in the end even against the wisdom of the Creator: **ואמרו איכה ידע אל ויש דעה בעליון**.
- **He is hated,** and so lives in fear and mistrust, and his plans are frustrated: **מפר מחשבות ערומים ולא תעשינה ידיהם תושיה**.

Even if he reaches the top

If he does attain the power and kingship he wanted, "you wanted to be a prince, you wanted to be an MP, you wanted to be a great minister," then:

- **Jealousy and hatred,** even from people he never harmed: **בלי עון ירוצון**. As soon as they see him in power, they want to kill him: **ועתה לכו ונהרגהו**.

The Rabbi tied this to that week's parasha, Vayeshev. Yosef had his dreams, and his brothers felt he was aloof and above them, "and so they felt it's time to kill him." They threw him in a pit; "of course, it was all part of Hashem's plan."

- **Constant fear.** He can never eat flour that is not sealed or drink water that has not been guarded, for fear of poison. Every day he sits under the edge of a sword, **כי כפסע ביני ובין המות**.
- **No one tells him the truth.** People do not tell him when he is wrong, because of his position, so he carries on. Meanwhile they speak badly of him behind his back, and in the end the Creator's judgment falls on him: **ובית המלך האזינו כי לכם המשפט**.

Why Hashem gave us the love of status

ולא נטע הבורא יתברך בנפש האדם אהבת השררה והגאוה, כי אם בעבור שתכסוף בהם לגמולו לעולם הבא

"This is very interesting." Hashem planted the desire to be raised above others only so that we would long for our reward in the World to Come, as it says, **לא יגרע מצדיק עיניו ואת מלכים לכסא, וישיבם לנצח ויגבהו**.

The Rabbi brought the Gemara that **in the World to Come each person is singed by the canopy of his fellow**: "I was in class with that person. How did he end up having that huge portion of the world to come, and I'm in such a lowly position?" That needs explaining, he said, but it shows the drive. "I want to be better than you in the sense that I want to be the best person that I can be. That's appropriate."

Good jealousy: *kin'at soferim*

Related to this is **קנאת סופרים תרבה חכמה**, the jealousy of scholars increases wisdom. The Rabbi clarified the halacha of jealousy. According to all opinions, there is no Torah prohibition on *feeling* jealous. What the Torah forbids is acting on it: seeing what someone else has, and scheming and planning to dispossess him and take it yourself. Feeling jealous "is not necessarily a great character trait to have, but it's not forbidden."

One of his teachers always said that one should be jealous of others in spiritual matters, "in a good way, not in a way where it defeats a person." You see what someone else has achieved and think, "I can do the same. What's stopping me?" That spurs you on. "How did he or she get that car? How did she get that house?... That's bad jealousy. That's mundane jealousy." A better word than jealousy, he suggested, is something that spurs you on.

Chapter 13: Revenge (*Nekamah*)

The tenth group: "There are some people who insist on always being right. Life is about being right... If somebody wrongs me, *oy va'avoy*, I'm going to make sure they recognize their wrong. I'm going to teach him or her a lesson."

Their argument

וראו אחרים כי הטוב במה שיכוון האדם בעולם הזה שינקום מאויביו

- **Revenge removes grief from the soul.** When you are wronged, sorrow settles in your heart. When you see your enemy fall, you feel happy, your anger subsides and the bad thoughts go: "Why did she do this to me? Why did he do that?"
- **People learn not to mess with you.**
- **Hashem promises it to the righteous: הן יבשו ויכלמו כל הנחרים בך... תבקשם ולא תמצאם אנשי מצתך**.

The Rabbi connected this to the previous chapter. "You feel lower than them." By taking revenge I bring them down, "so now we're equal again. You're not higher than me... That's why revenge is so sweet."

Saadia: it is all vanity

והתבוננתי כל מה שזכרו והנה הם הבלים

(The Rabbi said he did not understand the next two lines of the Hebrew, and moved on.)

- **A black sea.** When the mind is set on the enemy, it falls into a black sea, which the Rabbi read as depression. Every day a new scheme: **חשבו רעות בלב**. "You're full of toxicity. That's the word we would use nowadays."

- **No mercy.** His heart fills until he cannot spare anyone or accept any plea: **נפש רשע אותה רע, לא יחן בעיניו רעהו**.
- **He spends everything on it,** like the Medes **אשר כסף לא יחשבו וזהב לא יחפצו בו**. The Rabbi: "Look at the countries like Iran, where internally they've got terrible economic issues, and yet they're still willing to finance terror." Any logical person would say, invest in your own economy. "No, because revenge is more important... It distorts."
- **Others pay the price.** To kill his enemy he would kill a thousand friends, or himself: **תמות נפשי עם פלשתים**, said Shimshon. Innocent bystanders do not matter to him.
- **He forgets Hashem: ועדת עריצים בקשו נפשי ולא שמוך לנגדם**.
- **He often fails,** like the king of Moav against the king of Edom, **ולא יכלו**.
- **It rebounds on him: כורה שחת בה יפל**.
- **Even if he succeeds,** he has sinned, and no one can save him from it except the person he harmed: **אדם עשק בדם נפש עד בור ינוס אל יתמכו בו**.
- **It is a false hope.** For those who believe in fate, how can one stand against fate? (Saadia disproved fatalism in an earlier essay.) And for us, **אנשי אמת**, who believe everything is in Hashem's hands, it is **תוחלת נכזבה**, a vain hope, to stand against the Creator of heaven and earth.
- **Isolation.** People hate him, rejoice at his downfall, and no one cares for him when he is ill, **אין כהה לשברך**.

The neighbour and the eye

The Rabbi told a story he said is written in the sefarim. A man who was always jealous of his neighbour did a mitzvah, and in a dream was told he could have anything he wished, on one condition: whatever he received, his neighbour would receive double. "You want to be a billionaire, you can be... you'll have two billion, he'll have four billion." He thought hard, and finally said: "Please gouge out one of my eyes." Then his neighbour would lose both. "You could ask for anything, but I prefer to lose myself and to be harmed rather than my neighbor getting more than me." Revenge "can completely destroy a person's rationality."

When is the desire for revenge right?

אבל נטעה בנפש אהבת הנקמה לקחת דין הבורא מן המחזק בעוזו

It was planted in us so that we would exact the Creator's justice from those who do wrong by force, so that the world is set right: **לבקרים אצמית כל רשעי ארץ להכרית מעיר ה' כל פעלי און**. To punish and stop wrongdoers: that is the right use.

A question to come back to

The Rabbi left the class with one line to think about, "which is a big debate in the Rishonim actually." Saadia calls it a vain hope to stand against the Creator, "everything's up to Hashem." The famous question: **can a person harm another when Hashem has not decreed it?** "Hashem has decreed upon you to have a nice day today. And now I have free will to come and ruin your day... Do I have the ability to do that?" Saadia seems to be saying no. It is tied to that week's parasha and the Or HaChaim on **ונראה מה יהיו חלמתיו**. He will spend the beginning of the next shiur on it.

Summary

1. **Building up the world:** brings worry, debt, jealousy and taxes. The desire exists so that we have a home and food.
2. **Long life:** Saadia sees it as more sorrow and more sin; we love life so as to rise to the next world. The Rabbi: the Torah promises long *days*, not long years.
3. **Status and power:** society needs authority held by wisdom. The desire exists to drive us towards the greatest portion in the World to Come, like *kin'at soferim*.
4. **Revenge:** toxic, ruinous and a vain hope against Hashem's will. Its place is justice against wrongdoers.

Coming Up

- **No shiur for the next two weeks.** The class resumes in January.
- **Next term:** first, the question of whether one person can harm another without a divine decree; then the last three extremes, wisdom alone, worship alone and rest alone, followed by Saadia's chapter on balance in life and music. "This will take us two shiurim maximum." Then a new sefer.
- **Tomorrow (Tuesday):** the Rambam's Principles of Faith continue with the third principle, *ein lo guf*. Thursday night's shiur as usual.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/AcW5ZW6MajY · More shiurim: rabbikada.com